



Figures of the Bible

Stories of the men and women of the Bible, and what their
lives teach us

A cloud of witnesses surrounding us

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Introduction

Imagine sitting in a great assembly, surrounded by men and women who lived thousands of years ago, each of them carrying a story that — if you truly knew it — would change the way you see your life. This book is an invitation to such an assembly: we will listen to Abraham and Joseph, Moses and David, Daniel and Elijah and Esther, then to Peter and John and Paul, and finally to our mother, the Virgin Mary.

We are not here to read dry historical biographies, but to discover that these people were not flawless angels. They were human beings exactly like us: they were afraid, they hesitated, they stumbled, they wept — and yet God used them in astonishing ways. Their stories are not told to impress us, but to encourage us.

The Bible itself calls them "a great cloud of witnesses" surrounding us (Hebrews 12:1), like a crowd in an arena cheering us on as we run the race of life. Each chapter of this book tells the story of one person simply, then draws from it one clear lesson you can live out today, and closes with a short prayer you can lift from your heart.

This book is written for the ordinary reader: it needs no theological background and no dictionary. You will find chapter references to go back to if you wish, and very few direct quotations from Scripture; the rest is retold in our own words, with respect for the biblical text and for the tradition of our Coptic Orthodox Church.

A word of advice before you begin: do not read the book in one sitting. Take one chapter at a time, and give yourself space to reflect: where am I in this story? And what lesson is God speaking to me today? The goal is not to know more, but to live better.

And because we in the Coptic Church honor the saints without worshipping them, you will find the same balance in this book: we learn from these heroes without lifting them above their humanity, and we imitate their faith without forgetting that all glory belongs to God who worked in them. They are witnesses, not gods; lamps, not the sun.

We have taken care that every story is faithful to the Bible: we neither add invented events nor remove what is difficult. David really fell, Peter really denied, Elijah really sank into depression. This honesty is the secret of Scripture's power: it shows us man as he is, and grace as it is.

So are you ready? Open your heart before you open these pages, and pray a small prayer: Lord, speak to me through these witnesses. Then begin reading, trusting that the God who spoke to Abraham in Ur, to Daniel in Babylon, and to Peter on the shore, still speaks today.

Now let us begin the journey: from the land of Ur, where Abraham heard a voice that changed the course of history, to Bethlehem and Nazareth, where a young girl said a "yes" that changed the destiny of all mankind.

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Chapter 1

Abraham: Father of the Faithful

Abraham lived in the city of Ur, a wealthy city that worshipped idols. He was no prophet and no priest, but an ordinary man of seventy-five, married to Sarah and childless. Suddenly he heard God's voice say to him: "Get thee out of thy country, and from thy kindred, and from thy father's house, unto a land that I will shew thee" (Genesis 12:1). Notice that He did not tell him where — only "unto a land that I will shew thee."

Picture the scene: a man in his seventies asked to leave his home, his family, and his security, and to walk toward the unknown. He did not ask for a map or guarantees; instead, "Abram departed, as the LORD had spoken unto him." This is the first step on the journey of faith: to obey before you understand, and to walk before you see the whole road.

And God promised him great promises: descendants as numerous as the stars of heaven, and blessing for all the families of the earth. But the years passed: year after year, ten years, fifteen, twenty-five full years — and the promise was still unfulfilled. Abraham was an old man, Sarah was old, and human logic said: it is over.

In a moment of weakness Abraham listened to Sarah's suggestion and fathered Ishmael through Hagar the maidservant, trying to "help" God fulfill the promise. But God's plans do not need our hurried assistance; Ishmael was not the son of the promise. How often do we too try to force our own solutions instead of waiting for God's timing?

Then came the greatest moment of all: "Take now thy son, thine only son Isaac, whom thou lovest, and get thee into the land of Moriah; and offer him there for a burnt offering" (Genesis 22:2). What a test! The son he had waited a hundred years for — the very son of the promise — he is asked to offer as a sacrifice. And yet "Abraham rose up early in the morning" — he neither delayed nor argued.

He climbed the mountain with his son, the wood, and the fire, and Isaac asked innocently: "Behold the fire and the wood: but where is the lamb for a burnt offering?" The believing father answered with words that will never die: "My son, God will provide himself a lamb for a burnt offering." And at the last moment, before the knife could fall, the angel of the LORD called to him from heaven, and he found a ram caught by its horns, which God had prepared.

There on the mountain Abraham named the place "Jehovah-jireh" — "the LORD will provide" — a lasting witness that God never asks anything of us in vain, and that He provides the substitute at the right moment. God did not want Isaac's death; He wanted Abraham's whole heart: do you love Me more than the dearest thing you own?

Nor was Abraham's faith a theory but a daily life: wherever he settled, he built an altar and called on the name of the LORD. When his herdsmen quarreled with the herdsmen of Lot his nephew, Abraham yielded his right and let Lot choose the better land — and Lot chose fertile Sodom. But God said to Abraham: lift up your eyes and look; all the land you see I will give to you. Whoever yields for the sake of peace, God repays.

And when Lot was taken captive in the war of the kings, Abraham did not say "he deserves it." Instead he armed his men and rescued him. A believer's heart holds no grudge, even against one who wronged him by a selfish choice. After the battle, Melchizedek king of Salem came out with bread and wine and blessed him, and Abraham gave him tithes: an early image of the priesthood and the altar.

The New Testament bears witness to Abraham: "Abraham believed God, and it was counted unto him for righteousness" (Romans 4:3). He was not justified by his works but by his faith. If you think God accepts you because of your perfection, look at Abraham: he was accepted because he believed the promise. Believe today that God loves you and is able to fulfill His promise in your life, and this trust will be counted to you as righteousness.

The lesson: obedience and faith even when we cannot see. Abraham did not see the land before he walked to it, nor the descendants before he believed the promise, nor the ram before he raised the knife. True faith is not

understanding everything, but trusting the One who promised. Today God may ask of you a step you do not understand: a change, a leaving, a sacrifice — remember the father of the faithful, and walk.

Prayer: Lord, teach me to obey You as Abraham obeyed, to walk toward Your promises even when I cannot see the road. And when the fulfillment of Your promise is delayed, give me the patience to wait instead of rushing with my own solutions; and when You ask of me what is precious, remind me that You are "Jehovah-jireh": the LORD who sees and provides. Amen.

Chapter 2

Joseph: From the Pit to the Throne

Joseph was Jacob's favored son, wearing a coat of many colors his father had given him, and dreaming dreams in which he saw his eleven brothers bowing down to him. But instead of keeping the dreams in his heart, he told them to his brothers, and their jealousy grew until "they could not speak peaceably unto him."

One day his father sent him to check on his brothers in the field. They saw him from afar and conspired against him: "Behold, this dreamer cometh; come now therefore, and let us slay him, and cast him into some pit." But Reuben saved him from murder, so they contented themselves with stripping him of his coat of many colors and throwing him into an empty pit — and then they sat down to eat. What hardness of heart!

A caravan of traders passed by, and they sold him for twenty pieces of silver, and he was carried to Egypt as a slave. The pampered boy became a slave in Potiphar's house. Yet Scripture repeats a sentence like a refrain: "The LORD was with Joseph, and he was a prosperous man." True prosperity is not in circumstances, but in God's company.

In Potiphar's house came the moral test: his master's wife tried to seduce him day after day, and he fled from her, leaving his garment in her hand, saying: "How then can I do this great wickedness, and sin against God?" Notice that he did not say "sin against my master" but "against God" — to him, integrity was worship before it was ethics.

And the reward was... prison! The lying woman accused him, and he was thrown into prison unjustly. Yet even in prison "the LORD was with Joseph." There he interpreted the dreams of the king's cupbearer and baker, and asked the cupbearer to mention him to Pharaoh — but the cupbearer forgot him for two full years. Human forgetfulness is painful, but God's timing is precise.

Then Pharaoh dreamed of the fat and lean cows, and the full and thin ears of grain, and the cupbearer remembered Joseph. The young Hebrew stood before

the greatest king on earth and interpreted the dream: seven years of plenty followed by seven years of famine — and he offered a practical plan for storing grain. Pharaoh set him second over all the land of Egypt. From the pit to the throne in a single step, because God had been preparing him all along the way.

The famine came, and his brothers came to Egypt seeking grain, and bowed down to him without recognizing him — and the old dream was fulfilled. Joseph tested them to see whether they had changed, then could no longer restrain himself: "I am Joseph your brother, whom ye sold into Egypt." They wept and trembled, but he embraced them and spoke the golden words: "As for you, ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good" (Genesis 50:20).

In prison Joseph did not sit nursing his grievances; he became responsible for all the prisoners, until the keeper of the prison said he looked to nothing that was under his hand. Faithfulness in prison is what qualified him for faithfulness in the palace. God watches you in secret before He lifts you up in public.

When he stood before Pharaoh, he did not credit the interpretation to himself but said: "It is not in me: God shall give Pharaoh an answer of peace." Then he laid out a sound economic plan for the years of plenty and famine. True faith does not cancel out reason and planning; it sanctifies them.

After Jacob's death, the brothers feared Joseph would take revenge, and sent pleading for mercy. Joseph wept and said: "Fear not... am I in the place of God?" What profound humility! The avenger sits in God's place, but the forgiver leaves judgment to God. He promised to sustain them and their children, and died an old man, full of days, leaving the charge that his bones be carried up at the Exodus: faith even beyond death.

The lesson: forgiveness, and trust that God turns evil into good. Joseph did not take revenge on those who sold him, nor bear a grudge against those who wronged him, because he saw God's hand behind every event. Every pit in your life may be a ladder to a throne you never imagined, and every injustice may be raw material for God's good plan. Forgive, trust, and wait.

Prayer: Lord, give me Joseph's heart that forgives, and his eyes that see Your hand in every event. When I am wronged, teach me not to take revenge; when I am forgotten, remind me that You do not forget; and when I suffer, fix in my heart the truth that You turn evil into good. Amen.

Chapter 3

Moses: The Reluctant Leader

Moses was born a Hebrew slave in Egypt, at a time when Pharaoh was killing the Hebrew baby boys. His mother hid him for three months, then placed him in an ark on the Nile; Pharaoh's daughter found him and raised him in the palace as a prince. But he never forgot his roots.

At forty he saw an Egyptian beating a Hebrew, and he killed him and buried him in the sand, thinking no one had seen. But the news spread, and Moses fled to Midian, married there, and tended sheep for forty full years. The prince became a forgotten shepherd in the wilderness — or so he thought.

One ordinary day he saw a bush burning with fire yet not consumed. He drew near to look, and heard the voice: "Moses, Moses... Draw not nigh hither: put off thy shoes from off thy feet, for the place whereon thou standest is holy ground." God was calling him to return to Egypt and bring His people out of bondage. The mission was impossible by every measure.

And here began the famous string of excuses: "Who am I, that I should go unto Pharaoh?" God answered: "Certainly I will be with thee." Then: "What shall I say to them about Your name?" He said: "I AM THAT I AM" — the eternal One. Then: "They will not believe me" — so He gave him signs: the rod becoming a serpent, the hand becoming leprous and being healed.

The excuses did not end: "I am not eloquent... I am slow of speech, and of a slow tongue." What a wonder! The God who made the mouth says to him: "I will be with thy mouth, and teach thee what thou shalt say." At last he said it plainly: "O my Lord, send, I pray thee, by the hand of him whom thou wilt send" — find someone else, Lord! So He gave him Aaron his brother to speak for him.

The reluctant Moses returned to Egypt with a shepherd's rod and confronted the greatest empire in history. Ten plagues, then the night of the Passover, then the great Exodus. At the Red Sea the people stood terrified with the enemy behind them, and Moses spoke his immortal words: "Fear ye not, stand

still, and see the salvation of the LORD... The LORD shall fight for you, and ye shall hold your peace." And the sea parted!

Moses led the people forty years in the wilderness, bearing their grumbling and stubbornness, and interceding for them when God would have destroyed them. He did not enter the Promised Land because of a single mistake, but God Himself buried him, and Scripture testifies: "There arose not a prophet since in Israel like unto Moses."

When Moses first stood before Pharaoh, Pharaoh increased the bondage instead of lightening it, and the people grumbled against Moses and Aaron. Even one sent by God may meet rejection at first. But Moses did not turn back: a divine calling is not measured by people's reaction.

In the wilderness, when the people thirsted and grumbled, Moses struck the rock and water came out. When the serpents bit them, he lifted up the bronze serpent, and everyone who looked at it was healed — a symbol of the cross, as Christ Himself explained. God was teaching His people lesson after lesson, and Moses was the faithful mediator between God and the people.

Before his death he climbed Mount Nebo and looked at the Promised Land from afar, then "Moses the servant of the LORD died there, and he buried him." He did not enter the land, but he entered glory. And centuries later he appears with Elijah on the Mount of Transfiguration, speaking with Christ! The one who failed to enter a land became a witness of heaven's glory.

In his final days Moses gathered the people and preached his great farewell sermon in the book of Deuteronomy, reminding them of God's faithfulness in the wilderness and warning them against forgetting, then blessing the tribes one by one. A true leader does not depart before handing the whole message to those who come after him.

The lesson: God uses the weak when they trust Him. Moses was no orator and no confident leader, but a man of excuses with a stammer. Yet God did not choose the most capable; He chose the available, and turned a shepherd's rod into an instrument of miracles. Do not say "Who am I?" but say "Who is with me?" — for the strength is not in you, but in the One who sent you.

Prayer: Lord, how many times I have said to You, "Send someone else"! Forgive my hesitation, and teach me to trust that You will be with my mouth and with my weakness. Take my excuses and turn them into obedience, and make me an instrument in Your hand, however small I am in my own eyes. Amen.

Chapter 4

David: A Man After God's Own Heart

David was the youngest of eight brothers, a shepherd boy in Bethlehem whom no one noticed. When God sent Samuel to anoint a king from the house of Jesse, David was not even invited to the feast! But God said to Samuel: "Man looketh on the outward appearance, but the LORD looketh on the heart" — and the shepherd boy was anointed king in secret.

Then came the moment of glory: Goliath the giant defied the army of Israel for forty days, and no one dared face him. Young David stepped forward with a sling and five smooth stones, and said to the giant: "Thou comest to me with a sword, and with a spear, and with a shield: but I come to thee in the name of the LORD of hosts." One stone to the forehead, and the giant fell. The power was not in the stone, but in the name.

The people loved him, and King Saul envied him and hunted him for years, seeking to kill him, while David fled from cave to cave. Twice he caught Saul and could have killed him, but refused, saying: "I will not stretch forth mine hand against the LORD'S anointed." Even toward his enemy his heart was pure.

Then came the terrible fall: he saw Bathsheba from the roof and took her, then arranged the death of her husband Uriah in battle to cover his sin. The prophet who slew Goliath, the king who refused to kill his enemy, became an adulterer and a murderer. Sin respects no one's glorious past.

So God sent Nathan the prophet, who told him the story of the rich man who took the poor man's only lamb. David was furious and said: "The man shall surely die!" Then Nathan spoke the word that pierced his heart: "Thou art the man." David cried out: "I have sinned against the LORD!" — an immediate confession, with no excuses and no evasion.

From the depths of repentance was born Psalm 51, the most beautiful prayer of repentance in Scripture: "Have mercy upon me, O God, according to thy lovingkindness... Create in me a clean heart, O God; and renew a right spirit

within me." David did not ask for the consequences to be erased; he asked for a new heart.

God accepted his repentance, and David remained king, and from his line came Christ Himself. Scripture calls him "a man after God's own heart" — not because he never fell, but because every time he fell he returned with a broken heart. God is not looking for the perfect, but for the repentant.

As a youth in the wilderness, tending the sheep, David learned to play the harp and to sing praise. When an evil spirit troubled Saul, David would play and the king would be refreshed. A gift used for God becomes a blessing to others — even to enemies.

As king, David wanted to build a house for God, but God said to him: you shall not build Me a house; I will build you a house — a lineage and a kingdom forever. From David's line came Christ, "Son of David," as the blind man cries out in the Gospel. God's promises are always greater than our dreams.

In his old age, when his son Adonijah tried to seize the throne, David established Solomon as king according to God's promise. And David died "full of days, riches, and honour." The one who began as a forgotten shepherd ended as a king who founded the lineage of Christ: this is what God does with those who surrender their hearts to Him.

David was also a prophet and a psalmist: he wrote the Psalms the Church still prays today, and prophesied of Christ's sufferings and resurrection: "They pierced my hands and my feet," and "Thou wilt not leave my soul in hell." The little shepherd became the voice of inspiration sung by believers in every generation.

The lesson: falling is not the end, for repentance restores us. However great your sin and however long your wandering, the door of repentance stands open. Do not justify yourself, do not delay, do not despair; say it as David said it: "I have sinned against the LORD" — and you will hear the voice of grace say: "The LORD also hath put away thy sin." A new beginning is possible today.

Prayer: Lord, like David I have sinned against You. I do not justify myself nor hide my weakness; I cry with him: "Create in me a clean heart, O God." Wash

me, and I shall be whiter than snow; restore to me the joy of Your salvation,
and make my fall a ladder for my return to You, not a pit for my despair. Amen.

Chapter 5

Daniel: Steadfast in Exile

Daniel was a Jewish youth of about sixteen when he was carried captive to Babylon with the nobles of Jerusalem. He found himself in the heart of a pagan empire, far from the temple, his family, and his homeland, in the court of a mighty king. Everything around him invited him to dissolve and forget.

The first test came at the king's table: Nebuchadnezzar ordered that the captive youths be fed from the king's food and wine — food sacrificed to idols and forbidden by the Law. Daniel refused with gentle courage, and asked to be tested for ten days on vegetables and water only, because he "purposed in his heart that he would not defile himself."

Notice that he did not refuse because it was rich food, but because his principle was dearer than his appetite. After ten days their faces appeared better than all the youths'. The first lesson: whoever honors God in small things — in a morsel of food — God honors in great things.

The years passed and kingdoms changed: Babylon fell and Darius the Mede came, and Daniel, an old man in his eighties, was still faithful in his work, until the officials envied him. They searched for fault in his administration and found none, "forasmuch as he was faithful." So they decided to trap him at his point of strength: his faith.

They persuaded the king to sign a decree: whoever asks a petition of any god or man except the king for thirty days shall be cast into the den of lions. Daniel heard of the decree — and what did he do? He "went into his house; and his windows being open in his chamber toward Jerusalem, he kneeled upon his knees three times a day, and prayed, and gave thanks before his God, as he did aforetime." He neither hid his prayer nor changed his habit.

Daniel was cast into the den of lions, and the king spent the night fasting and sleepless. At dawn he ran to the den and cried: "O Daniel, servant of the living God, is thy God, whom thou servest continually, able to deliver thee from the lions?" And the voice came from the darkness: "My God hath sent his angel,

and hath shut the lions' mouths." Daniel came out unharmed, "because he believed in his God."

The secret of Daniel was not the night in the den, but the ordinary nights before it: three times a day, every day, for decades. The lions' mouths were not shut in the den, but in the prayer chamber. Whoever stands firm in secret will stand firm in public.

God gave Daniel wisdom above all the wise men of Babylon: he interpreted Nebuchadnezzar's dream of the great statue, revealing to him that the kingdoms of men pass away while "the God of heaven shall set up a kingdom, which shall never be destroyed." The captive youth became counselor to kings, because "an excellent spirit" was in him.

On the night Babylon fell, when Belshazzar saw the hand writing on the wall, the aged Daniel was called to interpret the writing: "MENE, MENE, TEKEL, UPHARSIN" — God has numbered your kingdom and finished it. That very night Babylon fell. God's word stands firm, and however high kingdoms rise, they are in His hand.

Daniel saw visions of the distant future — of the Son of Man coming with the clouds of heaven — prophesying of Christ centuries before His coming. At the end of his life the angel said to him: "But go thou thy way till the end be: for thou shalt rest, and stand in thy lot at the end of the days." The faithful one in exile has a portion in the end.

Daniel was a man of prayer, not a man of politics: when he wanted to understand a vision, he fasted three weeks and prayed until the angel came to him. And when he read in the book of Jeremiah that the captivity would last seventy years, he did not celebrate but "set his face unto the Lord God, to seek by prayer and supplications, with fasting, and sackcloth, and ashes." True greatness is known in the prayer chamber, not in the palace.

The lesson: faithfulness in small things before great things. Do not wait for the "big moment" to show your faith; begin today: regular prayer, a small principle you will not compromise, integrity in your work. Daniel did not plan for the day of the den, but the day of the den revealed what he had built in secret. Build your faith in the daily habit, and God will carry you on the day of testing.

Prayer: Lord, teach me Daniel's faithfulness: to be faithful in little before much, steadfast in my prayer every day, courageous in my principles even as a stranger. And when I face the "den of lions" in my life, remind me that Your angel is able to shut mouths. Amen.

Chapter 6

Elijah: The Fiery Man of Prayer

Elijah appeared suddenly in the days of the wicked King Ahab, with no introduction and no recorded lineage, like lightning in a dark sky. He stood before the king and said: "As the LORD God of Israel liveth, before whom I stand, there shall not be dew nor rain these years, but according to my word." Then he vanished! One word shut the heavens for three and a half years.

God sustained him in a marvelous way: at the brook Cherith the ravens brought him bread and meat morning and evening. When the brook dried up, He sent him to a poor widow in Zarephath of Sidon, blessed her flour and oil so they did not run out through the famine, and raised her son from death. God provides for His servants from where they least expect.

Then came the great day of Carmel: Elijah challenged the four hundred and fifty prophets of Baal before all the people. They built two altars and laid on the sacrifice with no fire, and he said: "The God that answereth by fire, let him be God." The prophets of Baal cried from morning till noon and cut themselves, and there was no voice, nor any that answered.

Then Elijah stepped forward alone, repaired the altar of the LORD, poured water over it three times until the trench was full, and prayed a short, simple prayer: "Hear me, O LORD, hear me." The fire of the LORD fell and consumed the burnt sacrifice, the wood, the stones — and licked up the water! The people fell on their faces crying: "The LORD, he is the God!"

After the fire, Elijah climbed to the top of Carmel to pray for rain. He bowed, putting his face between his knees, and sent his servant seven times to look toward the sea. Six times the servant returned saying: "There is nothing." But Elijah did not stop. On the seventh: "Behold, there ariseth a little cloud out of the sea, like a man's hand." He said: hurry! And the heavy rain came.

Persevering prayer opens shut heavens.

But after this great victory, Jezebel threatened to kill him, and Elijah fled in fear and depression, asking for death under a juniper tree! Even the greatest

men of prayer pass through moments of weakness. God fed him and gave him rest, then spoke to him at Mount Horeb: not in the great wind, nor in the earthquake, nor in the fire — but in "a still small voice."

What a profound lesson: the God of fire on Carmel is the same God of the whisper in the cave. God is not always in the noise and the power; He often speaks to His children in stillness. Elijah learned that ministry is not only in great excitements, but in quiet listening.

In Zarephath, when he asked the widow for a cake first, before she and her son ate, the request seemed harsh — but it was a test of faith: "For thus saith the LORD: the barrel of meal shall not waste, neither shall the cruse of oil fail." The widow obeyed, and she and her household ate for many days. Whoever gives God first shall lack nothing.

When the widow's son died, Elijah cried to the LORD and stretched himself upon the child three times, and the child's soul came back to him: the first raising of the dead in Scripture! Elijah's God is the God of life, who weeps with those who weep and raises the dead.

At the end of his ministry Elijah did not die but went up to heaven in a whirlwind, with a chariot of fire and horses of fire; Elisha took his mantle and a double portion of his spirit. And Elijah appears with Moses on the Mount of Transfiguration. A man of prayer's story does not end in death but in ascension.

The lesson: prayer moves God's hand, and God speaks to the quiet. Elijah "was a man subject to like passions as we are, and he prayed earnestly that it might not rain: and it rained not" (James 5:17). A man like us! The difference is that he prayed in faith and persevered to the seventh time. Set aside time for quiet prayer every day, and you will discover that heaven is nearer than you think.

Prayer: Lord, give me Elijah's prayer: faith that shuts heaven and opens it, and perseverance that does not stop at the sixth time. And teach me to silence the noise of my heart to hear Your still small voice. Speak, Lord, for Your servant heareth. Amen.

Chapter 7

Esther: For Such a Time as This

Esther was a Jewish orphan raised by her cousin Mordecai in the Persian exile. She was no princess and no heiress, but an ordinary girl in a foreign land. Yet God was silently weaving the threads of her story, until King Ahasuerus chose her as queen over the whole Persian Empire — without knowing she was Jewish.

In the palace there was Haman, the second man in the kingdom, who hated the Jews and hated Mordecai for refusing to bow to him. He devised a satanic plot: he persuaded the king to sign a decree to destroy all the Jews on one appointed day! Imagine the terror: an entire people sentenced to death on a known day.

Mordecai heard, tore his clothes, put on sackcloth and ashes, and sent to Esther, imploring her to go in to the king and plead for her people. But the problem was that entering the king's presence unsummoned was punishable by death — even for the queen herself! And the king had not called for her in thirty days.

Esther hesitated at first, so Mordecai sent her the words history would immortalize: "Think not with thyself that thou shalt escape in the king's house, more than all the Jews... and who knoweth whether thou art come to the kingdom for such a time as this?" (Esther 4:13-14). Perhaps you did not become queen for glory, but for this moment!

Then Esther made her great decision: "I will go in unto the king, which is not according to the law: and if I perish, I perish." But before she took a step, she asked for her true weapon: "Fast ye for me three days, night or day: I also and my maidens will fast likewise." True courage begins on the knees before it appears in the palace.

Esther went in to the king, and he held out the golden scepter to her — the sign of acceptance. With marvelous wisdom she did not reveal her request at once, but invited the king and Haman to a banquet, then to a second banquet,

where she exposed the plot. The king was furious, and Haman was hanged on the gallows he had prepared for Mordecai, and a new decree went out that saved the Jews.

The day that had been appointed for their death became a feast — the Feast of Purim, which the Jews celebrate to this day. The frightened Jewish orphan became the savior of her people, because she understood that her position was not a privilege but a mission.

Before she became queen, Esther spent a full year of preparation in the house of the women, under the care of Hegai the chamberlain, in whose sight she "obtained favour." Divine grace goes before a person and opens hearts to them, even in the palaces of strangers.

Mordecai sat daily at the king's gate, where he uncovered a plot to assassinate the king and reported it through Esther, and it was written in the book of the chronicles. He was not rewarded at the time, but God was storing up his honor for the right day: when God troubled the king's sleep on the night before Haman's plot!

What wondrous providence: the king could not sleep, so the chronicles were read, and he remembered Mordecai and ordered him honored; Haman walked in at that very moment to ask for Mordecai's hanging, and the king ordered him to honor Mordecai himself! God does not forget your faithfulness, even when the reward is delayed.

After the deliverance, Esther and Mordecai asked that what had happened be written in a book and preserved for generations — and so the book of Esther stands in Scripture as an eternal witness that God preserves His people. Ever since, Purim has been kept: the book is read, there is rejoicing, and gifts are given to the poor. True deliverance becomes a feast of thanksgiving and giving.

The lesson: courage in its time. God may place you somewhere you did not choose — a job, a family, a responsibility — not for your comfort but for your mission. And when your "such a time as this" moment comes, do not flee and do not delay: pray and fast as Esther did, then step forward with courage. History is made in moments like these.

Prayer: Lord, open my eyes to see why You placed me where I am. And when my moment comes, give me Esther's courage: to risk my comfort for the sake of truth, and to begin with prayer before the step. And if I am afraid, remind me: "for such a time as this" I am here. Amen.

Chapter 8

Peter: From Denial to Shepherd

Simon was a simple fisherman in Galilee when Jesus looked at him and said: "Follow me." He left the nets at once and followed Him, and Jesus named him "Peter" — the rock. He was impulsive and bold, the first to speak and the last to be silent: a disciple with a big heart and a mouth sometimes faster than his thoughts.

One stormy night the disciples saw Jesus walking on the water, and Peter cried out: "Lord, if it be thou, bid me come unto thee on the water." He said: "Come." Peter stepped down from the boat and walked on the water — until he saw the strong wind, grew afraid, and began to sink, crying: "Lord, save me!" Immediately Jesus stretched out His hand and caught him.

Peter was the first to confess: "Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God" — and Jesus blessed him. But immediately afterward he tried to keep Jesus from going to the cross, and heard the severe rebuke: "Get thee behind me, Satan." Peter lived the mountaintops and the valleys in a single day — exactly like us.

On the night of the arrest, Peter cut off the ear of the high priest's servant in defense of his Master, then followed Him from afar to the high priest's courtyard. There, by the charcoal fire, a simple servant girl asked him: "Art not thou also one of his disciples?" He denied. Then again. Then a third time, with cursing and swearing: "I know not the man!" And immediately the cock crew.

"And the Lord turned, and looked upon Peter." What a look! Not a look of anger, but a look of wounded love. "And Peter went out, and wept bitterly." The rock had fallen; the man who had said hours before, "Though all men shall be offended because of thee, yet will I never be offended," was shattered. Self-confidence was broken — and grace remained.

But the story did not end at the cock's crow. After the Resurrection, on the shore of the Sea of Tiberias, Jesus prepared breakfast of broiled fish for Peter

— at another charcoal fire, erasing the fire of denial. Three times, matching the three denials, He asked him: "Simon, son of Jonas, lovest thou me?" And each time the broken Peter answered: "Yea, Lord; thou knowest that I love thee." And He said to him: "Feed my sheep."

Jesus did not say to him, "Have you fixed what you broke?" — He restored him to service at once. On the day of Pentecost, Peter — who had denied before a servant girl — preached before thousands, and three thousand souls believed in a single day. The denier became a preacher, the fugitive became a shepherd, because Christ rebuilds those who are broken.

After the Holy Spirit came, Peter and John healed the lame man at the temple gate, and Jerusalem was stirred. They were arrested, and the council threatened them not to speak in the name of Jesus; Peter answered with courage: "Whether it be right in the sight of God to hearken unto you more than unto God, judge ye." The coward had become courageous by the Holy Spirit.

When Ananias and Sapphira lied to the Holy Spirit, Peter rebuked them firmly. And when he was imprisoned and beaten for the Name, he went out "rejoicing that they were counted worthy to suffer shame for his name." The one who feared a servant girl came to rejoice in beatings for Christ!

Peter wrote two epistles full of hope for the suffering: "the God of all grace... make you perfect, stablish, strengthen, settle you." In the end he was martyred in Rome, crucified upside down, because he did not count himself worthy to be crucified like his Master. The denier became a martyr: this is the workmanship of grace.

The lesson: failure is not your identity, for Christ rebuilds you. You may have denied your faith by your actions, or fallen into what you swore never to return to, and you think God is finished with you. But He looks at you as He looked at Peter: a look that restores you, not a look that condemns you. Come to Him with the tears of repentance, and you will hear Him ask: "Lovest thou me?" — then He will send you out again.

Prayer: Lord Jesus, like Peter I have denied and grown weak. Do not let my failure define me; define me Yourself by Your grace. Ask me as You asked him:

"Lovest thou me?" — and I will answer with a broken heart: Yea, Lord, Thou knowest. Rebuild my life, and make me a shepherd of Your sheep. Amen.

Chapter 9

John the Beloved: The Disciple of Love

John was a young fisherman with his brother James, until Jesus called them and they left their father and the nets and followed Him. At first he was hot-tempered: when a Samaritan village refused to receive Jesus, he and James suggested, "Shall we command fire to come down from heaven, and consume them!" — so Jesus named them "Boanerges," sons of thunder.

But something wonderful happened to this "son of thunder": the closer he drew to Jesus, the more the anger melted and love took its place. At the Last Supper, while everyone wondered who would betray the Master, John was "leaning on Jesus' bosom" — the disciple whom Jesus loved. Closeness transforms.

When all the disciples fled on the night of the cross, John remained standing at the cross with the Virgin Mary. From the cross, in the cruelest moments of pain, Jesus looked at him and said: "Behold thy mother" — and entrusted His mother to him. John took her into his own home from that hour and cared for her as his mother until her repose, as the Church has received.

John lived long — the only one of the apostles who was not martyred — exiled as an old man to the island of Patmos. There he saw the great Revelation and wrote the book of Revelation, then wrote his Gospel and his epistles, all revolving around one word that became his signature: love.

"God is love" (1 John 4:8): four words in which John summed up all theology. And he wrote: "Beloved, let us love one another: for love is of God." The son of thunder who wanted fire on the Samaritans became the apostle of love who writes: "He that loveth not his brother whom he hath seen, how can he love God whom he hath not seen?"

It is told of his old age that he was carried into the church and would say only one sentence, repeated: "My little children, love one another." When they asked why he repeated it, he answered: "Because it is the Lord's commandment, and if you keep this alone, it is enough." To him, love was not a

slogan but the summary of a lifetime.

What was the secret of this transformation? Not study, not training, but closeness. John clung to Christ's bosom and heard the beating of His heart, and his heart fell into rhythm with his Master's. Whoever draws near to fire grows warm; whoever draws near to love learns to love. John did not ask to become loving; he asked to be near — and love came as fruit.

John was one of the three closest disciples — Peter, James, and John — whom Jesus took to the Mount of Transfiguration and to the garden of Gethsemane. He saw the glory of the Transfiguration and heard the Father's voice, and saw the Master's sweat like drops of blood. Closeness to Christ means sharing His glory and His suffering together.

At the Last Supper, Peter asked John to find out from the Master who the betrayer was, because John was the nearest. And when all fled, John followed Jesus to the high priest's courtyard and went in with Him, because he was known to the high priest. True love does not flee in hardship.

Tradition tells that John shepherded the churches of Asia Minor from Ephesus, and that when he was exiled to Patmos he was an old man past ninety. He outlived all the apostles, to witness that love outlives persecution, and that the last word in history belongs not to the beasts but to the Lamb.

In his epistles John warns against counterfeit love in words only: "My little children, let us not love in word, neither in tongue; but in deed and in truth." To him, love is not a warm feeling but tangible deeds: feeding the hungry, visiting the sick, bearing with the weak. Whoever says he loves God but does not love his brother — his love is empty talk.

The lesson: closeness to Christ produces love. Do not try to "train" yourself in love by force; draw near to its source. Sit at His feet in prayer, lean on His bosom in the Gospel, and you will find your heart softening gradually: you forgive faster, anger slower, and love those who were difficult. Love is the fruit of closeness, not the fruit of effort.

Prayer: Lord Jesus, make me like John: near to You, leaning on Your bosom, hearing the beating of Your heart. Melt the thunder of my anger and make me a person of love. And teach me to care for those You entrust to me, as John

cared for Your mother. Amen.

Paul: From Persecutor to Apostle

Saul was no irreligious man; he was very religious: a zealous Pharisee, learned in the Law. But his zeal was blind: he persecuted Christians, dragging men and women to prison, and consented to the stoning of Stephen the first martyr, guarding the clothes of those who stoned him. He thought he was serving God, while he was fighting Him.

On his way to Damascus, carrying letters to arrest the Christians there, the unexpected happened: "suddenly there shined round about him a light from heaven: and he fell to the earth, and heard a voice saying unto him, Saul, Saul, why persecutest thou me?" Trembling, he asked: "Who art thou, Lord?" And the answer that changed history came: "I am Jesus whom thou persecutest."

What a staggering discovery! Saul thought he was persecuting weak men, and found he was persecuting Christ Himself. The Church is not a human institution but the body of Christ: whoever touches it touches Him. Saul rose from the ground blind, was led into Damascus, and remained three days without sight, without eating or drinking: three days of death to the old man.

God sent to him Ananias, a simple disciple who was afraid of Saul! But he obeyed, laid his hands on him, and said: "Brother Saul." Imagine: the persecutor called "brother"! Scales like scales fell from his eyes, he regained his sight, rose and was baptized, and began at once to preach: "that he is the Son of God."

His life was turned upside down: the persecutor became persecuted for Christ. Five times he was scourged with forty stripes minus one, once he was stoned, three times shipwrecked, a night and a day he spent in the deep; he hungered and thirsted and wandered. Yet he would say: "God forbid that I should glory, save in the cross of our Lord Jesus Christ."

Amid all this suffering he heard the greatest promise: "My grace is sufficient for thee: for my strength is made perfect in weakness" (2 Corinthians 12:9). So he cried out joyfully: "Most gladly therefore will I rather glory in my

infirmities, that the power of Christ may rest upon me." Weakness to him was no longer shame, but a dwelling place for God's power.

Paul wrote more than half the books of the New Testament, founded churches in Asia and Europe, and carried the Gospel from Jerusalem to Rome. The man who wanted to imprison Christians became himself a prisoner for Christ, and wrote letters of joy from prison! In the end he was martyred in Rome, finishing the race well.

In Damascus, after his baptism, Paul began preaching in the synagogues that Jesus is the Son of God; the Jews were confounded and sought to kill him, so the disciples let him down by the wall in a basket. The great apostle began his ministry escaping in a basket over a wall! God humbles Himself to use the humble.

Then he spent years in Arabia and Tarsus, unknown, until Barnabas came and brought him to Antioch. From there he set out on his three missionary journeys, traversing Asia and Europe, founding churches and writing epistles. The one who once traversed cities to arrest Christians now traversed cities to preach Christ!

In Rome, imprisoned awaiting trial, he wrote: "I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith: henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness." He regretted nothing: not the prisons, not the scourgings — for every pain was for Christ. This is how the race ends: with a crown, not with regret.

The lesson: no one is beyond God's grace. However dark your past — persecution, atheism, addiction, sins you are ashamed to name — the One who changed Saul in a moment on the road to Damascus is able to change you today. Do not say "it is too late," and do not say "I am too bad for God to accept me." Grace seeks out the farthest people to make of them the greatest witnesses.

Prayer: Lord, You who did not despair of Saul the persecutor, do not despair of me. Shine Your light on my road as You shone on the road to Damascus, and let the scales fall from my eyes that I may see You. Turn my dark past into a testimony of Your glory, and make my weakness a dwelling place for Your

strength. Amen.

Chapter 11

The Virgin Mary: Full of Grace

In the little town of Nazareth lived a girl betrothed to a man named Joseph. She was no queen and no heiress, but a simple girl unknown to anyone outside her village. Yet heaven knew her well, and God sent to her the greatest of His angels, Gabriel, with the greatest tidings in history.

"Hail, thou that art highly favoured, the Lord is with thee: blessed art thou among women." Mary was troubled at his words, so the angel reassured her: she would conceive and bear a son and call Him Jesus — "He shall be great, and shall be called the Son of the Highest." She asked innocently: "How shall this be, seeing I know not a man?"

He answered: "The Holy Ghost shall come upon thee, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow thee: therefore also that holy thing which shall be born of thee shall be called the Son of God." And here, in a moment of silence for which the whole universe held its breath, the young girl spoke the word that changed the destiny of mankind: "Behold the handmaid of the Lord; be it unto me according to thy word" (Luke 1:38). One "yes" opened the door of salvation to the world.

That "yes" was not easy: it meant pregnancy before marriage in a society that stoned the adulteress; it meant misunderstanding from her betrothed Joseph; it meant a sword that would pierce her own soul, as old Simeon prophesied. Yet she spoke it with no conditions and no further questions: "Be it unto me according to thy word" — total surrender.

She went with haste to Elizabeth, was filled with the Spirit, and sang: "My soul doth magnify the Lord, and my spirit hath rejoiced in God my Saviour." Notice that she said "my Saviour" — she too needed salvation — yet she is the one full of grace, chosen to be the Mother of God, as our Church calls her: the Theotokos.

Mary lived a life of silent contemplation: she "kept all these things, and pondered them in her heart." At the wedding in Cana she noticed the wine

running out before anyone else did, and interceded with her Son, saying to the servants the words that sum up all her faith: "Whatsoever he saith unto you, do it." And she says it to us too, every day.

She stood at the cross and did not flee like the rest of the disciples. She saw her Son and her God hanging in pain, the sword piercing her soul as Simeon had prophesied. But she remained standing: true faith stands at the cross and does not flee from suffering. From the cross her Son entrusted her to John, and John to her.

When she visited Elizabeth, the babe leaped in Elizabeth's womb, and she was filled with the Holy Spirit and cried out: "Blessed art thou among women, and blessed is the fruit of thy womb! And whence is this to me, that the mother of my Lord should come to me?" The first to confess Christ's divinity in the New Testament: a babe in his mother's womb!

In the manger at Bethlehem she brought forth her firstborn Son, wrapped Him in swaddling clothes, and laid Him in a manger, because there was no room for them in the inn. The Queen of heaven gives birth to the King of kings in a manger! Then she fled with Him to Egypt from Herod's face — and Egypt became a refuge for the Holy Family, and our land was blessed by His footsteps.

After the Ascension, Mary was with the disciples, "continuing with one accord in prayer," awaiting the coming of the Holy Spirit on the day of Pentecost. Then she departed to heaven, and the Church has honored her through the ages: "Hail, thou that art highly favoured" — we repeat it in every prayer. The one who said "yes" in Nazareth became the mother of the whole Church.

Our Coptic Church honors her with a special honor: we call her the Mother of God, we name churches after her more than after any saint, we fast her fast for fifteen days in August, and we chant her the Theotokias every day in the Midnight Praise. Whom God has magnified, the Church magnifies; and she who said "My soul doth magnify the Lord" — the Lord magnified her in every generation: "from henceforth all generations shall call me blessed."

The lesson: total surrender to God's will. Mary did not understand everything — "How shall this be?" — yet she surrendered without understanding.

Surrender is not the resignation of the despairing, but the trust of the loving: to say "be it unto me according to thy word" in sickness and in health, in joy and in sorrow, when you understand and when you do not. And whoever surrenders all to God, God fills all with grace.

Prayer: O thou that art highly favoured, pray for us. And O Lord, grant me the surrender of Your mother: to say "be it unto me according to thy word" in every circumstance of my life, to keep Your word pondering it in my heart, and to stand at Your cross and not flee. By the intercessions of the Mother of God, have mercy on us and save us. Amen.

Conclusion

And so our journey with the cloud of witnesses is complete: Abraham taught us faith, Joseph forgiveness, Moses that God uses the weak, David that repentance restores us, Daniel faithfulness in small things, Elijah the power of prayer, Esther courage in its time, Peter that failure is not the end, John that closeness produces love, Paul that no one is beyond grace, and our mother the Virgin total surrender.

The Apostle says: "Wherefore seeing we also are compassed about with so great a cloud of witnesses, let us lay aside every weight, and the sin which doth so easily beset us, and let us run with patience the race that is set before us" (Hebrews 12:1). These are not merely stories of the past, but living witnesses cheering you on now: if God could use them, He is able to use you too.

Now a question I leave with you: which of these figures spoke to your heart most? Are you in "Ur," needing to obey and go out? Or in "the pit," needing to forgive? Or at "the bush," hesitating and inventing excuses? Or have you fallen like David and need to return? Or are you standing before your "such a time as this" moment like Esther? Hear the voice, and answer.

And always remember that these witnesses were not perfect: Abraham lied twice out of fear, Moses killed a man, David committed adultery and murder, Elijah asked for death, and Peter denied. Yet God wrote their names in the book of life. Do not make your past an excuse for despair; make it material for grace.

Begin today with one small step: Daniel's daily prayer, or Mary's "yes," or David's tear, or Esther's courage. Do not wait for ideal circumstances, for God begins with the available, not the perfect. Choose one figure, choose one lesson, and live it this week.

Closing prayer: Lord, I thank You for the cloud of witnesses with which You have surrounded me. Make their stories light for my path and their lessons strength for my life. Help me to imitate their faith and not merely admire it, and to finish the race with patience until I meet You — and find myself one of

Your witnesses. By the intercessions of the Mother of God and all the saints.
Amen.